Everyday AI: Money & admin

6 step-by-step guides for real, everyday tasks

Money & admin

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Before you start — what this is, honestly

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What's inside

1. **Money & admin**
    1. Build a Simple Personal Budget Spreadsheet Using Any AI Assistant
    2. Decode Any Confusing Phone, Internet, or Medical Bill in 10 Minutes
    3. How to read and summarize a long lease or insurance policy with Gemini
    4. How to Use ChatGPT to Explain a Confusing Bill or Invoice
    5. How to Decode a Confusing Medical Bill with AI
    6. How to Read Through Insurance Policies and Bank Contracts with Claude

Money & admin

Build a Simple Personal Budget Spreadsheet Using Any AI Assistant

7 steps · Read online

By the end of this guide, you'll have a working monthly budget in Excel, Google Sheets, or Apple Numbers — even if you've never built a spreadsheet before. You'll simply ask an AI assistant (think of it as a chat-style helper that writes things for you) to design the structure, then copy the result into your favorite spreadsheet app. No formulas memorising, no finance jargon, no fuss.

Before you start

- An account with any AI assistant. ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, Copilot, Le Chat, and DeepSeek all work for this task — pick whichever you already have. Most have a free tier.
- A free spreadsheet app: Microsoft Excel (often pre-installed on Windows), Apple Numbers (on Mac), or Google Sheets (free in any browser at sheets.new).
- About 15 minutes the first time. A bit less once you've done it.

Step 1 — Open your AI assistant

Visit the website of your chosen AI assistant in a browser tab, or open its app on your phone. Sign in if needed. You'll see a chat box — usually a large text field at the bottom of the screen with placeholder text like "Message ChatGPT" or "Ask Gemini" inside it. If you don't have an account yet, look for a "Sign up" or "Get started" button; sign-up usually takes under a minute with an email address. Once you're in, the chat sits quietly waiting — the AI won't reply until you send something in Step 2. If your assistant offers a model selector (a small drop-down at the top of the chat), the default option is fine for budget work; no need to change it.

You'll know it worked when you can see the empty chat box and your cursor is blinking inside it.

Step 2 — Send the budget prompt

Click inside the chat box and type (or paste) your request. Press Enter, or tap the small upward-pointing paper-plane icon ➤ next to the box, to send. Within a few seconds, the AI starts typing a reply, and a budget table usually appears — complete with column headers like "Category", "Planned", "Actual", and a few sample rows. Some assistants (ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude) also offer a downloadable spreadsheet file; look for a small spreadsheet icon or "Download" link above the reply. If you see a paperclip 📎 icon for attachments, ignore it; you don't need to upload anything.

💬 Example: "Design a simple monthly budget spreadsheet for a single person earning a regular salary. Include columns for Category (Rent, Groceries, Transport, Utilities, Entertainment, Savings, Other), Planned amount, Actual amount, and Difference. Add 2 example rows per category. Keep it under 20 rows total."

You'll know it worked when the AI replies with a clearly formatted table — or a downloadable file link.

Step 3 — Check what the AI produced

Read the reply slowly. You'll usually see one of three things: (a) a neat table with rows and columns inside the chat, (b) a downloadable spreadsheet file, or (c) plain text describing the layout. Look for sensible categories (housing, food, transport, savings), clear column headers, and at least one mention of a formula — typically a "Difference" or "Total" column that subtracts one number from another. If the response feels too complex (mentions macros, pivot tables, or technical jargon), just reply asking for a simpler version. If the AI gave you plain text instead of a table, ask it to "format that as a table" in the same chat — it usually complies in one reply. Don't worry if the numbers are placeholders; you'll swap them for your own in Step 6.

You'll know it worked when you can clearly see columns, rows, and at least one total or formula reference in the reply.

Step 4 — Open your spreadsheet app

Switch to (or open) your spreadsheet app: Excel on Windows, Numbers on Mac, or Google Sheets in any browser (sheets.new is the fastest way to start). You'll land on a blank grid — columns labeled A, B, C across the top, rows numbered 1, 2, 3 down the side. In Google Sheets, click the colorful "+" button to start a new blank spreadsheet. In Excel, choose "Blank workbook". If spreadsheets are new to you, know this: each little rectangle is called a "cell", and you click one to type into it. The cursor blinks in the top-left cell (A1), waiting for your first entry.

You'll know it worked when you see an empty grid of cells ready to receive your budget.

Step 5 — Copy the AI's table into your spreadsheet

If the AI gave you a downloadable file, click "Download" and open it in Excel or Google Sheets — it lands as a ready-to-edit spreadsheet, and you can skip straight to Step 6. If the AI gave you a table inside the chat, click the small "Copy" icon that appears when you hover over the table (or highlight the text manually, then press Ctrl+C on Windows or Cmd+C on Mac). Click cell A1 in your empty spreadsheet and paste with Ctrl+V or Cmd+V. The categories and column headers appear neatly in row 1, with example data filling the rows below. If the paste comes out as one

long paragraph instead of a grid, undo with Ctrl+Z and try Ctrl+Shift+V instead — most apps offer a "paste as plain text" option that cleans up the formatting.

You'll know it worked when the AI's budget rows are sitting in your spreadsheet, ready to edit.

Step 6 — Add your real numbers and a totals row

Click each cell in the "Actual" or "Amount" column and type your own real spending for the past month — rough estimates are fine if you don't have receipts handy. Then click an empty cell directly below your last row and type a label like "Total". In the cell next to it (one column to the right), type =SUM(B2:B10), replacing B2 and B10 with the first and last row numbers of your actual data. Press Enter, and that cell instantly shows the sum. If your spreadsheet puts amounts in column C or D instead, change the letter to match. If you see #REF! or #VALUE! instead of a number, double-check the formula and the range — usually one cell was empty or the letters don't line up with your data.

You'll know it worked when the Total cell shows a single dollar figure that updates automatically as you change any of the amounts above it.

Step 7 — Save the file and make it yours

Save your file: in Google Sheets, click the title at the top-left to rename it (it saves automatically); in Excel, press Ctrl+S. From here, you can add new categories by typing into new rows, duplicate the sheet for a new month (look for a small "+" at the bottom of the screen), or come back to the AI assistant for more formulas like =AVERAGE() to see your typical weekly grocery spend. Try one small change right now — edit a number and watch the Total update. That single moment is when spreadsheets start to feel less like a chore and more like a quiet little superpower.

You'll know it worked when you've saved a file with your name on it, full of your real numbers, and the totals update themselves whenever you change anything.

Common mistakes

- **Asking for "the best budget spreadsheet".** There's no universal best, and the AI may invent complex features you don't need. Stick to simple columns (Category, Planned, Actual, Difference) and add complexity later only if you genuinely want it.
- **Pasting a screenshot of the AI's table into your spreadsheet app.** Most apps treat images as pictures, not data — so the cells stay empty. Use copy-and-paste from the text table, or download the file the AI offers.
- **Trusting the AI's placeholder numbers as personal advice.** The example figures are made up to show structure, not to recommend how you should spend. Replace them

with your own real spending, and treat any rule-of-thumb percentages the AI mentions as a starting point rather than gospel.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** A 10-minute weekly glance at your "Actual" column tells you where your money actually goes — usually a few small surprises (daily coffees, ride-shares, app subscriptions) you can adjust without much pain.
- **For your business or work:** The same template scales to a side-project budget, a freelance invoice tracker, or a small team's monthly expenses — just rename the categories.
- **If you're just getting started:** Open one AI assistant, paste the prompt from Step 2, and download whatever it gives you. Don't try to perfect it. A rough budget you actually use beats a perfect one gathering dust in a folder.

Try it now

Open your favorite AI assistant right now, paste the prompt from Step 2, and download the spreadsheet it produces. Spend two minutes renaming one column to something that matters to you — "Coffee", "Rent", "Dog walk" — and you're already further along than most people ever get.

Decode Any Confusing Phone, Internet, or Medical Bill in 10 Minutes

7 steps · Read online

> **In short:** You don't need an accounting degree to question a bill. Copy the line items into any AI assistant, ask it to flag anything unusual, and use that short list to decide what to push back on. No app, no signup, no jargon.

Bills use jargon to make you give up and pay. This guide shows a calm way to read any bill with an AI as your second pair of eyes, so you pay only what you actually owe. It works for phone, internet, and medical statements alike, and you don't have to finish it in one sitting.

Before you start

- **One bill you want to understand** — paper, PDF, or a photo on your phone.
- **Any AI assistant in a browser or app** — ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot, or another you already use. The free tier is enough.
- **About 10 minutes**, in one go or split across two short breaks.
- **A pen or note app** to mark up the line items as you go.

Step 1 — Find a quiet 10 minutes and put the bill in front of you

Sit down with the bill, your phone or laptop, and a piece of paper. Don't try to read it on the bus or while cooking — line items blur into each other when you're distracted. If the bill is paper, snap a clear photo so you have a digital copy to work with. If it's already a PDF in your email, open it on the same device you'll use for the AI assistant, so you can copy text straight from it.
💬 Example: a small note on your paper — "Today's goal: figure out what each line means and which ones look off." You'll know it worked when the bill is on screen, your AI tab is open next to it, and you've got a clear few minutes ahead.

Step 2 — Strip out personal details before you share anything

Before any line goes near an AI, remove identifying information — your full name, address, account number, payment card digits, and any claim or policy number. Scribble them out on paper, or cover them with rectangles in a free phone app. The AI only needs the line items, amounts, and dates. Personal details do not help and create unnecessary risk if a screenshot ever ends up in the wrong place. 💬 Example: keep visible — "$84.50 — Base Plan — Sept 3 to Oct 2". Black out everything else. You'll know it worked when the version you're about to share looks like a generic sample, with no name or number pointing back to you.

Step 3 — Paste the bill and ask one focused question

Copy the cleaned-up line items and paste them into your AI assistant. Then ask one specific question, not five. The best request is short and direct: "Look at these charges. Which ones look unusual, and what should I ask the company about each one?" That single sentence turns the assistant into a checklist-maker instead of a general explainer. If your first try produces a wall of text, reply "shorten to a bulleted list under 200 words" and it will reset. 💬 Example prompt to copy: "Here are the line items from my phone bill. For each charge, tell me: (1) what it usually means, (2) whether it's normal or worth questioning, (3) one question I should ask the provider." You'll know it worked when the assistant gives you a list where each charge has a small label — like "normal," "worth asking," or "likely duplicate."

Step 4 — Read the response like a checklist, not a verdict

The AI's reply is a starting point, not a final answer. Treat each line like a Post-it note: green means "I understand this and it matches my plan," yellow means "I want a human to explain it," and red means "I want this removed or credited." Don't argue with the bill yet — your only job here is to mark each charge. If the assistant flags something it can't identify, write "?" and move on; the next step is where you check those yourself. 💬 Example: mark "monthly plan $40" green, "regulatory fee $3.20" yellow (you don't know if it's accurate), and "international roaming $27" red (you didn't travel). You'll know it worked when you can count the yellow and red marks on one hand and feel ready to look them up.

Step 5 — Double-check the suspicious lines with the company itself

For every yellow or red mark, search the provider's official help pages for the exact phrase. Type the term in quotes — for example, `"universal service fund"` or `"device installment"` — and read the company's own definition. This second pass protects you from a confident-but-wrong AI answer. Most bills also have a phone number, chat, or "contact us" page; note the one you'll use so it's ready when you need it. 💬 Example search: type `"administrative fee"` plus the company's name into your browser to see how they explain the charge in their own words. You'll know it worked when every red and yellow line has either a clear explanation in your own words or a one-sentence question written next to it.

Step 6 — Send one short, polite message with a single focused question

Now write to the company. Keep it short, polite, and focused on one line item per message — not the whole bill. Front-load the question: "I'm reviewing my October bill and noticed a $27 charge labeled 'international roaming' for dates I didn't travel. Can you confirm what triggered this and which dates it covers?" Include the bill date and exact amount. If they answer clearly, decide whether to accept it, ask for a credit, or escalate. 💬 Example message you can adapt: "Hi, on

bill dated 3 October, line 'Equipment Fee — $12.00' appeared for the first time. I don't recall being notified about a new charge. Can you explain what this covers and the start date? Thank you." You'll know it worked when you get a specific answer — not a copy-paste paragraph — that either makes sense or gives you grounds to escalate.

Step 7 — Decide your next move based on what they say

If the answer resolves it, mark it green and move to the next yellow. If it's a copy-paste non-answer, reply once more asking for a specific date or reference number. If the charge turns out to be wrong, ask politely for written confirmation of the credit and how it will appear on your next bill. For medical bills especially, many regions have a patient advocate or billing hotline whose job is to translate line items. Save your email thread in case you need it later. 💬 Example closing reply — "Thanks. Could you confirm the credit amount in writing and the date it will appear on my next statement?" You'll know it worked when every flagged line is now green, yellow (waiting on the company), or removed — and you have a paper trail for each.

Common mistakes

- **Pasting a bill with your name, address, or account number still visible.** The fix: redact first, always. The AI only needs the line items and amounts to do this job.
- **Asking the AI ten questions at once.** The fix: one focused thing, then a follow-up. Shorter prompts give shorter, more useful answers.
- **Treating the AI's answer as proof of a billing error.** The fix: check the company's own help pages or a previous bill before you push back. The assistant can misread a code as a charge.
- **Sending a long, angry email with every yellow line at once.** The fix: one focused question per email gets a real answer; a wall of complaints gets a template.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** any time a bill arrives — phone, internet, streaming, utilities, medical — you can run it through this 10-minute routine and decide what to question, instead of paying on autopilot.
- **For your business or work:** the same habit works for vendor invoices, software subscriptions, and freelancer contracts. The AI is a triage nurse, not a doctor; the human on the other end still confirms.
- **If you're just getting started:** start with the bill that's been bugging you the longest. Even if you only save a small amount, the next bill will feel easier to read.

Try it now

Grab the most recent bill sitting on your kitchen counter, snap a photo, scribble out your name and account number, and paste the line items into any AI assistant with the prompt from Step 3. Ten minutes from now, you'll have a checklist — and a clearer head.

How to read and summarize a long lease or insurance policy with Gemini

6 steps · Read online

> **In short:** You can upload a long lease or insurance PDF to Google Gemini and ask for a plain-English summary that highlights the clauses you actually need to read before signing. The free version handles most everyday documents, and you don't need any technical skill.

A 40-page lease or a 25-page insurance policy is the kind of thing most people skim, sign, and regret later. Gemini can read the whole document for you, pull out the parts that cost money or restrict what you can do, and explain the legal-sounding words in everyday language. This guide walks through that process step by step, whether you're moving into a new apartment, choosing a health plan, or reviewing a contract your employer sent over. Gemini can give you a strong first pass — but remember, it's not a lawyer, and for big decisions the original document still matters.

Before you start

- **A Google account.** If you use Gmail or YouTube, you already have one.
- **A browser or the Gemini app.** On a computer, open any web browser. On a phone, install the Gemini app from your app store if you don't have it yet.
- **The PDF file.** Save the lease or insurance document to your phone or computer so you can find it quickly. If it's a paper document, scan it to PDF first — most phone camera apps can do this.
- **About 10 to 15 minutes.** That's all it takes to go from a confusing PDF to a clear summary.
- **Free or paid plan.** The free version of Gemini handles most everyday documents well. Some advanced features — like reading very long files or uploading many files at once — may require a paid plan; Gemini will tell you if it hits a limit.

Step 1 — Open Gemini and start a fresh chat

In your browser, go to **gemini.google.com** and sign in with your Google account if prompted. If you're on a phone, open the **Gemini app** instead. You'll see a clean chat window with a message box near the bottom and your Google profile picture in the corner. Click or tap inside the message box so the cursor blinks — that's how you know you're ready to type. Starting a new chat, rather than reopening an old one, keeps the document summary focused and easier to find later.

*If you don't see a chat box, look for a button labeled **"New chat"** or a **pencil icon** somewhere on the page.*

You'll know it worked when you see an empty message box with a blinking cursor, and your Google account name or avatar visible somewhere on screen.

Step 2 — Upload your PDF

Next to the message box, look for an icon that looks like a **paperclip**, a **"+"**, or the words **"Upload"** or **"Files"**. Click or tap it. A file picker will open — the same window you use to attach files to an email. Navigate to wherever you saved the PDF (your Downloads folder, Files app, or Google Drive), select the lease or insurance document, and confirm. The file will start uploading, which usually takes a few seconds for a normal-sized PDF. When it's done, you'll see the file name appear in the chat as a small chip or attachment.

*If the icon names don't match, try the **"+" or plus button** — most chat interfaces tuck uploads there.*

You'll know it worked when the filename shows up in the conversation as an attachment and the message box is ready for your first question.

Step 3 — Ask for a plain-English summary

Now type your first message. Be specific about what you want — vague prompts give vague answers. Ask Gemini to summarize the document in everyday words, and tell it which topics matter to you (money, rules, deadlines, restrictions). Press **Enter** or tap **Send**. Gemini will read through the PDF and write back a structured response. Don't worry if it takes 10–20 seconds — that's normal for long documents. Read the summary carefully, but remember it's a starting point, not the final word on what the contract means.

Example: *"Please summarize this lease in plain English. I want to know what I have to pay each month, what I'm not allowed to do, what happens if I break the rules, and how I can end the lease."*

You'll know it worked when Gemini returns a summary that mentions specific dollar amounts, dates, or rules from your document — not generic advice about leases in general.

Step 4 — Ask Gemini to flag the high-stakes clauses

A summary is useful, but the real value is knowing which sections could cost you the most money or get you in trouble. Send a second message asking Gemini to point out the parts you should read closely. The clearer you are about what "high-stakes" means to you (money?

termination? liability? privacy?), the more useful the list will be. If the list feels too long, ask Gemini to rank the top three so you don't have to chase every detail.

Example: *"Which clauses in this document could cost me the most money or cause the biggest problems if something goes wrong? List them and quote the key sentence from each one if you can."*

You'll know it worked when you see specific clause names, dollar amounts, or quoted phrases from your actual document — not generic warnings about "all contracts".

Step 5 — Ask follow-up questions about any confusing term

If a clause still doesn't make sense, copy a sentence from it and ask Gemini to explain it like you're twelve years old. This is the part most people skip, and it's often the most valuable — a single confusing phrase ("indemnify and hold harmless," "actual cash value," "joint and several liability") can hide thousands of dollars in real-world consequences. If Gemini's explanation still feels too formal, ask again in simpler words. You can keep asking as many follow-ups as you want in the same chat.

Example: *"What does 'indemnify and hold harmless' mean in everyday language? And does this clause apply to me as the renter, or only to the landlord?"*

You'll know it worked when you can explain the term to a friend in one short sentence, in your own words.

Step 6 — Save the summary somewhere you can find it

Once you have a summary and a list of important clauses worth re-reading, copy the key parts into a notes app, an email to yourself, or a simple document. Don't rely on the Gemini chat history alone — those conversations can be hard to find weeks later, and uploads sometimes expire. A short note with the date, the document name, the three biggest risks, and any open questions you still have is usually enough. If you sign the document, attach or link your notes so future-you knows what you agreed to.

If you'd rather skip the copy-paste, take a screenshot of the summary and save it to your phone. It's not searchable later, but it's better than nothing.

You'll know it worked when you can open your notes app right now and see, at a glance, the three most important things you learned from the document.

Common mistakes

- **Asking "summarize this" with no direction.** Gemini will give you a generic overview that misses what you actually care about. Tell it which topics matter: money, deadlines, restrictions, termination, who pays for what.
- **Treating the summary as the final answer.** Gemini is a starting point, not a lawyer or insurance advisor. For big decisions — a house, a surgery, a long business contract — re-read the original document or talk to a professional before you sign.
- **Uploading a scanned image instead of a real PDF.** If your document is just photos of pages, Gemini may not be able to read the text inside. Open the file and try to select a sentence; if you can't highlight any words, it's an image scan, not a text PDF, and you'll need a higher-quality scan with selectable text.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** Before you sign a lease, an insurance renewal, or a phone plan, you can spend ten minutes with Gemini and walk away knowing what you're actually agreeing to — instead of finding out the hard way when a fee shows up.
- **For your business or work:** Vendor contracts, freelance agreements, and client terms of service are exactly the kind of long PDFs that benefit from a quick AI pass before you forward them to legal or a partner.
- **If you're just getting started:** Pick one document you already have sitting in your email — a recent subscription, an old lease, even a saved terms-of-service page — and run it through Steps 1 to 3 today. Ten minutes, one real document, no risk.

Try it now

Open gemini.google.com (or the Gemini app), upload any PDF you already have — even an old utility bill or a saved terms-of-service page — and ask for a plain-English summary in the next two minutes. You'll know the whole flow works when you see your first AI-written summary of a real document, and you can scroll back through the conversation to find it again.

How to Use ChatGPT to Explain a Confusing Bill or Invoice

6 steps · Read online

> **In short:** Open ChatGPT, attach a photo of the bill, and ask it to translate the jargon into plain English. ChatGPT can explain what each charge probably means — but it can't verify the bill itself is correct, so call the company if something looks off.

Every month, millions of people stare at a bill packed with terms like "regulatory cost recovery fee," "prorated charge," or "facility rental" and have no idea what they actually paid for. You don't have to guess anymore. In about five minutes, you can turn that wall of small print into a short, plain-English explanation you can actually use.

Before you start

- **A ChatGPT account.** A free account works; ChatGPT Plus and Team give you more image uploads per day and faster replies.
- **The app or the website.** On a phone, install the **ChatGPT** app (iOS or Android). On a computer, open **chat.openai.com** in any modern browser.
- **The bill itself.** Either a paper copy on a table, or a digital version (PDF, screenshot, or photo from email).
- **Roughly 5–10 minutes.** Most of that is reading the explanation, not typing.

Step 1 — Get a clear photo of the bill

Lay the paper flat on a table in good light, then hold your phone straight above it — directly down, not at an angle. Make sure all four corners of the page are inside the frame and the small print at the bottom is readable. If the bill is already digital (PDF in your email, screenshot in your camera roll), use that file directly instead of photographing the screen.

If it looks different: If you're working from a paper bill and the corners keep curving in the photo, place a heavy book on the edges. If you're screenshotting an email bill, scroll down first so the whole thing fits in one image.

💬 Example: Take one photo straight down, then pinch to zoom and check the smallest line — if you can read it, ChatGPT probably can too.

You'll know it worked when you can read every line yourself when you zoom in. If the photo is blurry, cropped, or shadowy, ChatGPT will guess — and guesses about money are a bad idea.

Step 2 — Open ChatGPT and start a fresh chat

Open the ChatGPT app on your phone, or go to **chat.openai.com** in your browser. Look for a small **pencil icon** or a button labeled **"New chat"** — usually at the top-left corner of the screen. Tap it. A clean conversation opens, with just an empty message box at the bottom and no previous messages above it.

If it looks different: Some versions show a **speech bubble** with a plus sign, or a **"+"** button in the same spot. If you can't find it on mobile, tap the **menu icon (three lines)** in the top-left — your chats list opens, and you can tap "New chat" from there.

You'll know it worked when the screen shows a blank chat with only the message box at the bottom. Starting fresh matters because old messages can confuse the answer.

Step 3 — Attach the bill photo to your message

Inside the message box, look for a **paperclip**, a **plus (+)**, or an **image icon**. Tap it, then choose **"Photos"** or **"Camera"** on your phone, or **"Upload file"** on a computer. Pick the bill photo from your library. A small thumbnail of the image appears inside your message area, waiting to be sent.

If it looks different: On some versions of the app the image icon sits on the **toolbar just above the keyboard**, not inside the box itself. On a computer, you can also **drag and drop** the photo straight onto the chat window — no clicking needed.

You'll know it worked when a small preview of the bill is sitting in your message area, ready to go. If you see only text and no image, the upload didn't go through — try again.

Step 4 — Ask ChatGPT to explain it in plain English

Now, in the message box, type a clear request. Tell ChatGPT what kind of bill it is and ask it to walk you through each charge in everyday language. Tap **send** (the arrow or paper-plane icon). Within a few seconds, ChatGPT reads the image and starts typing a plain-English explanation line by line.

If it looks different: If the chat box appears empty after you tap send, check that your message contained **both** the image and your text — sometimes the image uploads but the words disappear. Resend them together.

💬 Example: "This is my home internet bill. Please list every charge on it in plain English, and flag anything that looks unusual or higher than I'd expect for a typical plan."

You'll know it worked when ChatGPT replies with a numbered list or short paragraph that names each line item and says what it means, then asks if you want a closer look at any of them.

Step 5 — Ask follow-up questions if something is still unclear

If a term or charge doesn't make sense, just type another message in the same chat. ChatGPT remembers what you just talked about, so you can ask **"What does 'prorated' mean here?"** or **"Is this a normal charge for internet?"** without re-uploading the bill. The more specific your question, the more useful the answer tends to be.

If it looks different: If ChatGPT seems to have lost the thread or replies with something generic, scroll up and confirm the photo is still visible in the conversation. If it isn't, attach it again in your new message.

💬 Example: "What does 'regulatory cost recovery fee' usually cover on these bills, and is it something I can ask the company to remove?"

You'll know it worked when you get a direct, plain answer to your specific question — not a generic reply and not a request to upload the bill again.

Step 6 — Save the explanation for later

Once ChatGPT has explained the bill, you'll probably want to keep that explanation. Look for a **copy icon** near the assistant's reply, or simply **highlight the text**, copy it, and paste it into Notes, an email, or a message to yourself. Some plans also offer a **"Share"** button near the top of the chat that creates a link to the whole conversation.

If it looks different: If you don't see any copy or share option, the simplest fallback is a **long-press on the text** (on a phone) or a **right-click → Copy** (on a computer), then paste wherever you keep notes.

You'll know it worked when you can open your Notes app (or wherever you pasted it) and read the explanation without going back to ChatGPT.

Common mistakes

- **Sending a blurry or cropped photo.** ChatGPT will fill in the gaps with guesses — and guesses about money are dangerous. Fix: retake the photo flat, in good light, with all four edges visible.
- **Asking "is this bill correct?"** ChatGPT can't compare the bill against the company's actual records, so it can only explain what the text says. If something still looks wrong after the explanation, call the company's billing line directly.
- **Uploading bills full of sensitive numbers.** Full account numbers, Social Security numbers, or detailed medical codes don't need to be on the photo — the charges do. Fix:

cover sensitive numbers with a piece of paper or a finger before snapping, or scribble them out with a marker.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** Next time an unfamiliar charge shows up on a phone, utility, or medical bill, you don't have to guess. A two-minute chat can translate the jargon into a list you actually understand.
- **For your business or work:** The same trick works on supplier or contractor invoices — useful for spotting strange line items before you pay, and for explaining a charge to a teammate who wasn't on the original call.
- **If you're just getting started:** Pick one bill you've been avoiding opening, snap a photo, and run it through. That single experiment will teach you more than any tutorial.

Try it now

Find the most recent bill you've been ignoring — utility, internet, phone, or medical — and snap a clear photo of it. Open ChatGPT, attach the image, and paste this prompt: **"This is my [type of] bill. Please list every charge in plain English and flag anything that looks unusual or higher than I'd normally expect."** Read the reply before you pay anything.

How to Decode a Confusing Medical Bill with AI

5 steps · Read online

> **In short:** Paste an itemized medical bill or insurance statement into any AI assistant and ask it to translate the jargon, list every charge, and flag anything that looks off — in plain English. The AI explains; it cannot dispute a bill or make medical decisions.

A medical bill arrives in the mail, or an Explanation of Benefits (EOB) shows up in your insurer's portal, and within five lines you've hit "CPT 99213", "allowed amount", and a number that doesn't match what you expected to pay. This guide walks you through using an AI assistant to turn that wall of codes and figures into a plain-English breakdown you can actually read — no medical or insurance background needed.

Before you start

- **The document itself**: an itemized medical bill, an EOB from your insurer, or both. Paper, PDF, or a photo on your phone all work.
- **An AI assistant**: any major one will do — ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude, Copilot, Le Chat, or DeepSeek. Free versions are usually enough for a single bill; longer documents may need a paid plan with a bigger context window (the amount of text the AI can read at one time).
- **A second screen is helpful but optional**: phone for the bill, laptop for the AI, or two browser tabs side by side.
- **About 15 minutes** for your first bill. You'll get faster on the second one.
- **Important limit**: AI can explain what a charge means. It cannot file an appeal, call your insurer, or tell you whether a procedure was medically necessary. Treat its output as a translation, not a verdict.

Step 1 — Make the bill digital

If your bill is on paper, you need it as text the AI can read. Open any free scanning app on your phone — most phones have one built in (look in your camera or notes app for a "scan document" option). Lay the bill flat, line up the corners in the camera frame, and snap. The app saves it as a PDF with selectable text. Already have a PDF in email or your insurer's portal? Just download it to your phone or computer. **If it looks different**: if you don't see a built-in scanner, search your app store for "free document scanner" — any top result works fine. You can also type the charges out by hand, though that's slower. Example: "Scan the front and back of the bill into one PDF named 'bill-jan2026.pdf'." You'll know it worked when the bill opens on your screen and you can highlight the words with your cursor — or, on a phone, long-press a word and see it selected.

Step 2 — Strip out personal details

Before you paste anything into an AI, take 60 seconds to remove identifying numbers. On a paper bill, use a marker or your finger to cover your full Social Security Number, member ID, and any bank or card numbers. On a PDF, print and mark it up, or copy the body text into a notes app and delete those numbers by hand. **If it looks different**: a quick rule of thumb — leave your name and the provider's name (the AI needs them for context), but remove any number that looks like an account, policy, or government ID. Some bills also print diagnosis codes that are very specific to your health; if that makes you uneasy, swap them for a generic description like "knee injury" before pasting. Example: "Black out my SSN, member ID, and the last four digits of my card before pasting." You'll know it worked when a stranger could read the document and follow it, but no one could use it to impersonate you or pull up your records.

Step 3 — Paste it in and ask for a plain-English summary

Open your AI assistant in a browser or app and start a new conversation. Paste the cleaned-up bill or EOB into the message field near the bottom of the screen. The message field is often labeled something like "Message" or "Ask anything," though your app may use different words — look for the long text box with a blinking cursor, just above or beside a send button. Ask the AI to explain it, and keep your first prompt simple — one request, one paragraph. **If it looks different**: if the document is very long and the AI says it was cut off, split it into two messages — first half in one prompt, second half in the next — and tell it to combine the analysis. Example: "Here's my itemized bill from a clinic visit. In plain English, please list every charge, what each one was for, what my insurance paid, and what I still owe. Flag anything that looks unusual." You'll know it worked when the AI gives you a structured answer — usually a short list of charges in everyday language, followed by a total or a clear note that it couldn't calculate one.

Step 4 — Ask follow-up questions about specific terms

Now zoom in. Pick any line you don't understand — a procedure code, a phrase like "allowed amount" or "patient responsibility", a charge that surprises you — and ask the AI about it. This is where the chat format really helps: you don't have to ask everything at once. **If it looks different**: if the AI's reply is too generic, paste the exact line back and ask about that one item only. Still vague? Try rephrasing — instead of "explain this", try "in one sentence, what does a 99213 CPT code usually mean, and roughly how much does it cost without insurance?" And if every line on the bill actually looks clear to you already, still ask the AI to flag any codes or charges it thinks are worth questioning — a fresh pair of eyes often catches something you skimmed past. Example: "On line 4 it says 'CPT 99213, allowed amount $84.20, patient owes $25'. What is a 99213, what does 'allowed amount' mean, and why is the patient share $25?" You'll know it worked when the AI names the procedure in plain words, explains each money

term, and tells you roughly how the numbers relate — usually with a note that exact prices vary by region and plan.

Step 5 — Sanity-check the totals and spot anything odd

Before you trust any of this, do your own quick math. The AI is good at explaining, but it can mis-add numbers or invent a percentage that wasn't in the original. Open your bill or EOB in another tab, grab a calculator (your phone has one), and add the charges yourself. Compare that to the AI's total. **If it looks different**: if the totals don't match, paste the raw lines back and ask it to re-add — most assistants catch their mistake on the second try. If the gap is large, treat the bill, not the AI, as the source of truth, and call the number on the bill to ask about it.
Example: "Please re-add every line on this bill and confirm the total. I'm getting $342.10 when I add it by hand but your last answer said $298.50." You'll know it worked when either the AI corrects itself and the new total matches yours, or it points to a specific line it had missed — and you've decided what to do with the gap.

Common mistakes

- **Pasting a bill with sensitive numbers still in it.** Even well-known assistants log conversations to improve their models. Strip SSNs, member IDs, and card digits first — Step 2 takes a minute and prevents a much bigger headache later.
- **Treating the AI's "this looks normal" as proof.** AI assistants can sound confident even when they're guessing. Use their output as a starting point, then confirm any big charge by calling the provider's billing line — the number is almost always at the top of the statement.
- **Asking the AI whether a charge is fair.** That's a judgment call that depends on your plan, your region, and the specific service. The AI can explain what a code is; only your insurer can tell you whether it should have been covered. For disputes, start with the provider's billing department, and if you want formal help, contact your state or country's insurance ombudsman.
- **Uploading a blurry photo of the bill.** If the AI keeps saying "I can't read this", re-scan in good light with the page flat. Bad input always produces bad output.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** the next time a confusing statement shows up, you'll spend 15 minutes instead of an afternoon figuring out what you actually owe — and you'll know exactly which line to call about if something looks wrong.
- **For your business or work:** if you run a small team, you can use the same workflow to help employees decode their first bills after a new benefits plan kicks in. It won't replace HR, but it cuts down on "what does this mean?" emails.

- **If you're just getting started:** try it first on an old, already-paid bill you no longer need to act on. You'll learn how the assistant responds without any pressure — and you'll have a much easier time when a real, current bill arrives.

Try it now

Pick any old medical bill or EOB you can find — even one you already paid. Strip the sensitive numbers, paste the rest into your favorite AI assistant, and ask: "Explain every line in plain English and tell me what I might want to question." That single two-minute ask is the whole skill.

How to Read Through Insurance Policies and Bank Contracts with Claude

6 steps · Read online

> **In short:** Paste any insurance policy, loan agreement, or bank contract into Claude and ask for a plain-English summary. Claude will flag hidden fees, exclusions, and tricky clauses — but it cannot replace a lawyer, and very long documents may need to be split into parts.

Insurance policies and bank contracts are written in a style called *legalese* — language that sounds official but is designed to be hard to read. A 30-page home insurance PDF often hides the answer to "am I actually covered if my pipe bursts?" in paragraph 47. Claude can read that whole document in seconds and explain it like a friend would over coffee. Here's how to use it without losing the details that matter.

Before you start

- A free Claude account at **claude.com** (the free plan is enough for short documents; very long contracts may need a paid plan with a bigger file upload).
- The contract or policy you want to read — either as a PDF file on your device, or as text you can copy from your email.
- About 10–15 minutes for your first try.
- A quiet moment. You'll want to actually read Claude's summary, not just skim it.

Step 1 — Open a fresh chat with Claude

Go to **claude.com** and log in. Click **"New chat"** at the top-left of the screen. A blank conversation box opens. Starting fresh matters because Claude remembers the previous conversation — and you don't want yesterday's homework question mixed up with today's insurance policy. If you're on the phone app, tap the **pencil or "New chat" icon** instead; if you can't find it, look for a button like **"Start new conversation"**. 💬 Example: there is nothing to type yet — just open the chat. You'll know it worked when you see an empty message box with a **paperclip icon** (for attaching files) and a **send arrow**.

Step 2 — Attach the document (or paste the text)

Click the **paperclip icon** 📎 to the left of the message box, then choose your file (PDF, Word, or a photo of a printed page usually works). If your contract is already open in another window, you can also simply copy the text — **Ctrl+C** on Windows or ⌘+**C** on Mac — and paste it straight into the chat box with **Ctrl+V** or ⌘+**V**. After you attach or paste, you'll see a small file thumbnail or a chunk of text appear in the box. If you don't see a paperclip, look for a **"+"**

button or an **upload icon** instead — apps change the icon from time to time. 💬 Example: a PDF named `home-insurance-2026.pdf` shows up as a thumbnail before you send. You'll know it worked when Claude replies that it has read the document and is ready for your question.

Step 3 — Ask for a plain-English summary first

Before asking tricky questions, ask Claude to give you the basics. A good first prompt tells Claude who you are and what kind of document it is. Type a short message in the box, then press **Enter** or tap the **send arrow**. Claude will write a multi-paragraph reply covering the main points. If the reply is too short or too long, follow up with "Can you go deeper on the parts a normal person would care about?" 💬 Example: "I'm a homeowner, not a lawyer. Please summarize this home insurance policy in plain English. Cover: what am I covered for, what am I NOT covered for, my deductible, and anything that could void my coverage. Keep it under 400 words." You'll know it worked when Claude's reply lists the key sections in everyday language, with no big unexplained words.

Step 4 — Ask Claude to flag the "gotcha" clauses

Now for the part that saves real money. Many contracts include clauses (sentences or whole sections) that limit what the company has to pay you — things like "we only cover damage from sudden events, not gradual wear." Type a follow-up question in the same chat. Claude uses what it already read, so you don't need to re-upload anything. If the reply feels vague, add "Give me at least five specific examples." 💬 Example: "Now read it again like a skeptical friend. List every clause that could limit my payout or surprise me. For each one, quote the original wording, then explain what it actually means in plain English." You'll know it worked when Claude gives you a bulleted list with both the original sentence and a plain translation — those are the spots to read twice in the real document.

Step 5 — Compare two offers side by side (optional but powerful)

If you're choosing between two insurance quotes or loan offers, open a second chat (back to **"New chat"**) and upload both documents — or paste both into the same chat one after the other. Then ask Claude to compare them on the points that matter to you. Claude reads both files in seconds and builds a comparison. Be specific about what you want to compare, because "which is better?" is too vague to answer well. 💬 Example: "I've pasted two home loan offers below. Compare them on: total interest paid over 5 years, early-repayment penalties, fixed vs variable rate, and any hidden fees. Show your work in a simple table." You'll know it worked when Claude produces a clean table or side-by-side list — and you can spot the better deal in about a minute.

Step 6 — Save the summary where you'll actually find it

Claude's replies disappear if you lose the browser tab. Before you close the chat, copy the most useful reply (the summary, the gotcha list, or the comparison) into a notes app, email it to yourself, or take a screenshot. On a computer, click and drag to highlight the reply, then **Ctrl+C** / ⌘+**C**. On a phone, long-press the text and choose **"Copy"** or **"Share"**. Saving this now means you don't have to ask Claude again six months later when you actually need the info. 💬 Example: paste into a note titled `home-insurance-summary-2026` so future-you can find it. You'll know it worked when you can close Claude, reopen your notes app, and see the summary waiting for you.

Common mistakes

- **Pasting only the first page.** Insurance policies often hide the most important exclusions near the end. If the file is long, upload the whole PDF instead of copying a paragraph.
- **Trusting the summary without checking the originals.** Claude is helpful, but it can occasionally miss a clause or misread a number. Always open the real document and confirm any decision that affects money or coverage.
- **Asking vague questions like "is this a good deal?"** Claude needs specifics to compare well. Name the criteria (fees, interest rate, coverage limits, cancellation terms) so the answer is useful.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** Reading a car insurance renewal no longer means an hour of squinting. Ten minutes with Claude gets you the parts that matter before you sign.
- **For your business or work:** Comparing supplier contracts or client terms of service becomes a 15-minute task instead of an afternoon — useful for freelancers and small-business owners who don't have legal staff on call.
- **If you're just getting started:** Pick one document you've been meaning to read — a bank fee schedule, a phone plan, an old insurance renewal — and run it through Steps 2 and 3 today. The habit starts there.

Try it now

Find one PDF or email attachment from your bank, insurer, or phone company that you've been avoiding. Open a new Claude chat, upload it, and paste this prompt: *"I'm not a lawyer. Summarize this in plain English, then list the three things in here that could cost me money if I don't know about them."* Read the reply once, then decide whether the document deserves a closer look — that one minute of friction-free reading is the whole point.